

Be your own devil's advocate, eliminate bias

Human brain has some rather unique features to be able to make quick decisions based on past experiences. This decision-making comes with some **limitations**. We are more likely to see what we expect to see, rather than what is actually there. This **phenomenon** is known as 'perceptual set'. **It**, therefore, **has** the **potential** to **lead to biased, erroneous** perception and subsequently wrong decisions. A familiar example is we being able to read a misspelt word correctly because our brains expect it to be spelt that way. It's a unique ability to selectively ignore what does not **conform to** established patterns and eliminate any confusion. The **cognitive apparatus** selectively **mutes** the **discordant** notes to maintain **harmony** of perception.

There is evidence to suggest that at any given moment, one sees only 20% of what one is seeing; 80% of what appears in our visual field is being 'generated' by our brain. Of the total inputs to the visual **cortex** that integrate and **mediate** our vision, only 20% of **neural** pathways come from the eyes; 80% come from other areas of the brain, such as those in charge of memory. It is now estimated that visual perception is 80% memory and 20% input through the eyes. Sensory information is not **transmitted** to the brain; it comes from it. **This infill**, or fill-in-the-blanks, **is** sourced from memory and other sensory **modalities** and experiences.

Therefore, any **decision**, or chosen option that's based on our perception **is** strongly impacted by a well-defined phenomenon called confirmation bias.

Confirmation bias is a psychological term for the human tendency to selectively **glean** information that supports one's position. This causes a bias towards confirming the decision made, seeking out only information that supports the decision.

It is a kind of **self-propagating mechanism**, which **paradoxically** focuses on factors that **lend credibility** to whatever position one has taken.

Decision-making is **fraught with** another **peril** – the powerful **undercurrent** of emotions that short charge reason and **blur** reality. A **combination** of cognitive bias **garnished** with generous emotional **toppings** **has** often **been the recipe for** disastrous judgements and decisions.

Human intelligence **perhaps** is unique in that it can affect its own **appraisal**. A blessing that's **ironically** called 'Devil's Advocacy'. Being one's own **Devil's Advocate** is a discipline that can **yield** rich **dividends**. This involves challenging and if required **negating** assumptions, arguments, and evidence of the chosen option.

A stance, that the **premise**, decision, or option taken **is** wrong. One has to investigate thereafter and find **inherent flaws**, possible misjudgements or miscalculations. An 'autocorrection' **of sorts** that splits the Self into two. One that has made the decision and another that questions the former.

The **kicking in** of this autocorrection mechanism **introduces** a delay that **differentiates** an **instinctive impulsive** act from an act **suffused** with **conscious deliberation** – an ability to **transcend from** being **merely** a decision-maker to simultaneously being an unbiased observer. An independent observer is no longer **subservient** to presumptions and biases and has a **self-indulgent** ego that refuses to accept one's limitations. To **err** is human; to review is divine.

Eliminating cognitive bias plays a crucial role in making correct decisions. This **endeavour** is particularly important when making critical, irreversible, life-changing decisions. **[Practice Exercise]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Advocate** (noun) – Proponent, Champion, Supporter, Defender, Backer समर्थक
2. **Bias** (noun) – Prejudice, Partiality, Tendency, Inclination, Leaning पक्षपात
3. **Limitation** (noun) – Constraint, Restriction, Drawback, Shortcoming, Weakness सीमा
4. **Phenomenon** (noun) – Occurrence, Event, Fact, Incident, Manifestation घटना
5. **Perceptual set** (noun) – It refers to a predisposition to perceive things in a certain way प्रत्यक्षात्मक प्रवृत्ति
6. **Potential** (noun) – Possibility, Capacity, Capability, Promise, Prospect संभावना
7. **Lead** (to) – (verb) – Cause, Result in, Bring about, Produce, Generate वजह बनना
8. **Biased** (adjective) – Prejudiced, Partial, Onesided, Slanted, Distorted पक्षपातपूर्ण
9. **Erroneous** (adjective) – Incorrect, Wrong, False, Inaccurate, Mistaken गलत
10. **Cognitive** (adjective) – Mental, Intellectual, Perceptual, Thinking, Reasoning संज्ञानात्मक
11. **Apparatus** (noun) – Mechanism, System, Structure, Framework, Device तंत्र
12. **Mute** (verb) – Silence, Suppress, Quieten, Stifle, Dampen दबाना
13. **Discordant** (adjective) – Conflicting, Inharmonious, Dissonant, Clashing, Jarring विरोधाभासी
14. **Harmony** (noun) – Balance, Accord, Unity, Consistency, Congruity सामंजस्य
15. **Cortex** (noun) – the outer layer of an organ in the body, especially the brain
16. **Mediate** (verb) – Facilitate, Moderate, Arbitrate, Intervene, Negotiate मध्यस्थता करना
17. **Neural** (adjective) – Nervous, Neuronal, Nerve-related, Cerebral, Brain तंत्रिका संबंधी
18. **Transmit** (verb) – Convey, Transfer, Send, Communicate, Pass on प्रसारित करना
19. **Infill** (noun) – Completion, Supplementation, Filling in, Augmentation पूर्ति
20. **Modality** (noun) – Method, Mode, Manner, Approach, System प्रणाली
21. **Glean** (verb) – Gather, Collect, Extract, Derive, Obtain इकट्ठा करना
22. **Self-propagating** (adjective) – Self-perpetuating, Self-sustaining, Self-renewing स्वतः प्रसारित
23. **Mechanism** (noun) – Process, System, Procedure, Operation, Device तंत्र

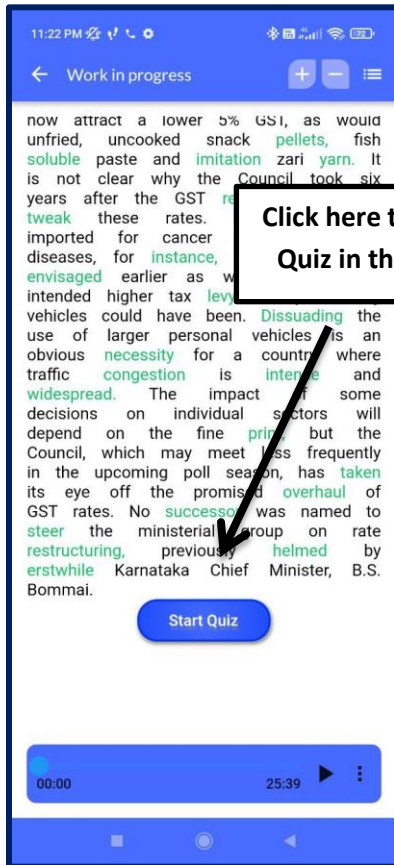
24. **Paradoxically** (adverb) – Contradictorily, Ironically, Unexpectedly, Illogically
विरोधाभासी रूप से
25. **Lend** (verb) – Give, Provide, Offer, Grant, Impart प्रदान करना
26. **Credibility** (noun) – Believability, Trustworthiness, Reliability, Plausibility
विश्वसनीयता
27. **Fraught** (with) – (adjective) – Filled, Laden, Charged, Full, Burdened भरा हुआ
28. **Peril** (noun) – Danger, Risk, Hazard, Threat, Jeopardy खतरा
29. **Undercurrent** (noun) – a feeling, especially a negative one, that is hidden but whose effects are felt अदेखा
30. **Blur** (verb) – Obscure, Dim, Cloud, Confuse, Distort धुंधला करना
31. **Garnish** (verb) – Decorate, Adorn, Enhance, Embellish, Trim सजाना
32. **Topping** (noun) – Addition, Enhancement, Decoration, Garnish, Covering ऊपरी परत
33. **Be the recipe for something** (phrase) – Cause, Lead to, Result in, Create, Produce कारण बनना
34. **Perhaps** (adverb) – Maybe, Possibly, Conceivably, Perchance, Potentially शायद
35. **Appraisal** (noun) – Evaluation, Assessment, Judgment, Estimation, Analysis मूल्यांकन
36. **Ironically** (adverb) – Paradoxically, Unexpectedly, Contradictorily, Sarcastically
विडंबनापूर्वक
37. **Devil's advocate** (noun) – someone who expresses an opinion they do not really hold in order to encourage a discussion about a subject विपक्षी वक्ता/दोषदर्शी
38. **Yield** (verb) – Produce, Generate, Provide, Bear, Give उत्पन्न करना
39. **Dividend** (noun) – Benefit, Profit, Gain, Return, Advantage लाभ/अंश
40. **Negate** (verb) – Nullify, Cancel, Invalidate, Deny, Reverse नकारना
41. **Premise** (noun) – Assumption, Proposition, Basis, Foundation, Hypothesis आधार
42. **Inherent** (adjective) – Intrinsic, Innate, Builtin, Natural, Essential निहित
43. **Flaw** (noun) – Defect, Fault, Imperfection, Weakness, Shortcoming दोष
44. **Of sorts** (phrase) – Of a kind, In a way, Sort of, Kind of, After a fashion एक प्रकार का

45. **Kicking in** (noun) – Activation, Starting, Beginning, Commencement, Initiation प्रारंभ
46. **Differentiate** (verb) – Distinguish, Separate, Discriminate, Tell apart, Set apart अंतर करना
47. **Instinctive** (adjective) – Intuitive, Automatic, Reflex, Natural, Innate सहज
48. **Impulsive** (adjective) – Spontaneous, Rash, Hasty, Unthinking, Reckless आवेगशील
49. **Suffuse** (with) – (verb) – Permeate, Infuse, Fill, Spread through, Bathe व्याप्त करना
50. **Conscious** (adjective) – Aware, Deliberate, Intentional, Mindful, Purposeful सचेत
51. **Deliberation** (noun) – Consideration, Reflection, Thought, Contemplation, Discussion विचार
52. **Transcend** (verb) – Surpass, Exceed, Rise above, Go beyond, Overcome पहुंचना, ज्यादा होना
53. **Merely** (adverb) – Only, Simply, Just, Barely, Solely केवल
54. **Subservient** (to) – (adjective) – Subordinate, Inferior, Subject, Dependent, Servile अधीन
55. **Self-indulgent** (adjective) – Hedonistic, Pleasureseeking, Gratifying, Pampering आत्मतुष्ट
56. **Err** (verb) – Make a mistake, Blunder, Slip up, Miscalculate, Stumble गलती करना
57. **Endeavour** (noun) – Effort, Attempt, Venture, Striving, Enterprise प्रयास

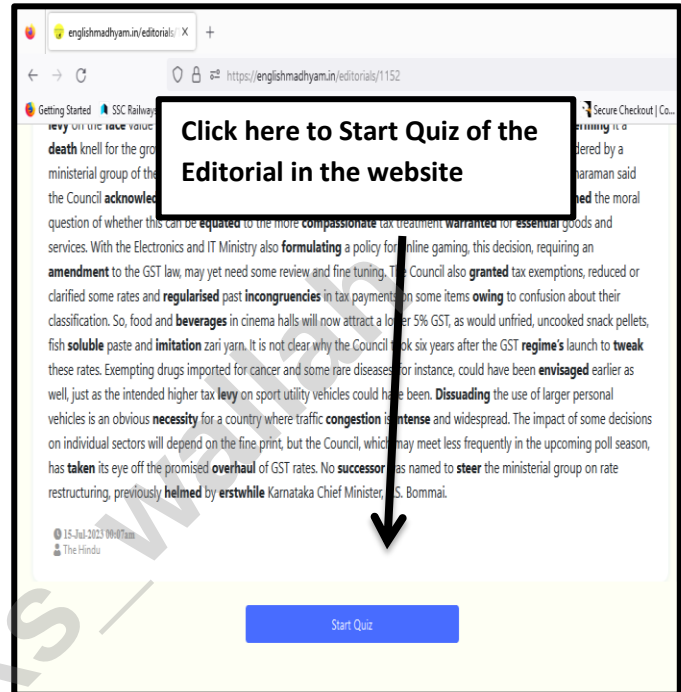
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Perceptual Set Bias** – The brain tends to see what it expects (based on past experiences) rather than reality, leading to potential misjudgments.
2. **Example: Reading Misspelt Words** – We often read misspelt words correctly because our brain auto-corrects based on expectations.
3. **Selective Perception** – Only **20% of vision** comes from actual visual input; **80% is constructed by the brain** using memory and expectations.
4. **Memory-Driven Perception** – Most of what we "see" is not raw sensory data but a reconstruction influenced by past experiences.
5. **Confirmation Bias** – People unconsciously favor information that supports their pre-existing beliefs, ignoring contradictory evidence.
6. **Self-Reinforcing Mechanism** – Once a decision is made, the brain seeks evidence to justify it, creating a feedback loop of bias.
7. **Emotional Influence on Decisions** – Strong emotions can override logic, further distorting judgment.
8. **Disastrous Judgments** – Many poor decisions stem from cognitive biases amplified by emotional reasoning.
9. **Devil's Advocacy as a Solution** – Deliberately challenging one's own assumptions helps counteract bias.
10. **Self-Critique Technique** – Splitting into a "decision-maker" and a "skeptical observer" improves objectivity.
11. **Autocorrection Mechanism** – Introducing a delay between impulse and action allows for rational reevaluation.
12. **Transcending Impulsivity** – Conscious deliberation separates instinctive reactions from well-considered choices.
13. **Ego & Presumptions** – An unbiased observer must resist the ego's tendency to defend flawed decisions.
14. **Error & Review** – Humans naturally err, but self-review ("to review is divine") minimizes mistakes.
15. **Critical for Major Decisions** – Eliminating bias is especially vital for irreversible, life-changing choices.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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